

counts, with a short description of each parameter listed below:

Ease Of Use: A measure of how easy the program is to install and configure. Ideally, there shouldn't be any configuration required—the program should be fully functional, without having to do anything at all. Plus, how good is the support provided?

Scanning: The aim of the scanning test was to determine the percentage of all malicious code that the antivirus software is able to detect. The results were used with the permission of AV-Test.org(www.av-test.org), one of the leading independent authorities in the field of virus testing. This is a project undertaken by the Business-Information-Workgroup at the Institute of Technical and Business Information Systems in Germany, in co-operation with GEGA IT-Solutions GbR.

Scheduling: This determines whether the program provide for scheduled scans that do not require user intervention and how easy is it to set up a custom scheduled scan.

Upgradeability: Any anti-virus program, no matter how good it might be, will become useless in a matter of weeks unless it provides access to the latest engine and anti-virus definition updates. In this category, we measured the period and duration for which free updates are available, and whether these updates are carried out automatically. Also, measured was how frequently the company released its updates.

Resource Utilisation: The amount of system resources used by the program is important enough to be gauged. This category includes the CPU and memory utilisation, and time taken for a full system scan.

All of these tests were run on our top-end test PC—an Intel 3.0 GHz with 800 MHz FSB CPU, Intel D875PBZ motherboard, 256 MB DDR333 RAM, a Seagate 120 GB SATA hard drive, running Windows XP Pro, Version 2002.

AVG 6.0 Free Edition

It's possible to get your hands on a product that provides a lifetime of cash-free service. That's right, Grisoft's AVG is freely available as a download at the company's Web site, with just a couple of catches—it can only be used on a standalone home PC, and not networked office PCs. It's virus detection is not exactly phenomenal, and you'll never get access to online technical support. However, it's a small price to pay for the benefits you get.

The first version of AVG Anti-Virus was released in 1991.

Since then, it's managed to capture half the market in its home country, the Czech Republic, and has looked to gain an entry into the lucrative US market by offering selected services for free. For a program that's completely free of cost, it comes off as the easiest to use package, and one that places the least burden on your system. Fine piece of work, this.

Price: Free ■ **System requirements:** Pentium class CPU, 128 MB RAM, platforms supported are MS-DOS, Windows 95, NT, 2000, XP, 98, Me ■ **Web site:** www.grisoft.com ■ **Grade:** A

eScan Virus Control Edition

MicroWorld Technologies is an Indian company with offices in India and the US. With technologies from Kaspersky Labs, its product, eScan Virus Control Edition has been targeted at securing desktop PCs from virus threats. It consists of an on-demand scanner and a real-time monitor, and includes only anti-virus features, unlike newer products such as eScan 2003.

This Indian entry does manage to exhibit top performance when it comes to detecting viruses, but falls short on user friendliness and configurability. The program interface looks ancient and intimidating as compared to its competitors. MicroWorld certainly has a long way to go as far as understanding its target audience is concerned.

Price: \$ 45.95 ■ **System requirements:** Pentium Processor, 64 MB RAM, 100 MB free Hard Disk space, Windows 95, 98, NT, 2000, Me, XP ■ **Web site:** www.mwti.com ■ **Grade:** B+

Anti-Virus 2003

Founded in 1988, F-Secure is headquartered in Helsinki, Finland. It claims that the its products are synonymous with ease of use and low load on systems. Unfortunately, the experience we had was a far cry from what was advertised.

The problem starts from the very moment you install the program. What you download happens to be just a small stub that needs to connect to the Internet to download the rest of the software—something we've never come across in any of the other programs. The result of is that when uninstalled, the program leaves a heap of files behind that need to be manually deleted—a definite no-no as far as ease of use is concerned. The worst part

Installing And Configuring McAfee VirusScan 7.0 Home Edition

STEP 1 Run the self-extracting installer. Choose a folder where you want the files to be extracted. Note this location, as you'll have to manually delete these files once the installation completes.

STEP 2 Choose the 'Typical Installation' type and follow the prompts. It'll take just a couple of clicks before the installation gets underway. Once the program installs, it'll automatically initiate a full system scan to flush out any viruses.

STEP 3 Launch VirusScan, if it isn't already open, by double-clicking on its icon in the system tray. If you haven't already registered the program, you'll need to click the link in the main window to



launch the registration program. Connect to the Internet, fill in the required fields, and the program automatically downloads the latest updates.

STEP 4 In the Tasks pane, on the left, click on 'Configure automatic protection settings'. All four checkboxes under the VirusScan section need to be checked. Now click on the Advanced button (see pic). As a final step, click again on the Advanced button. Enable the Heuristic Scanning check box and set the radio button to 'Enable macro and program file heuristics scanning'. This might slow down your system a wee bit, but better to be safe than sorry. Click on OK all the way through, and you're done.